



GenEd1091



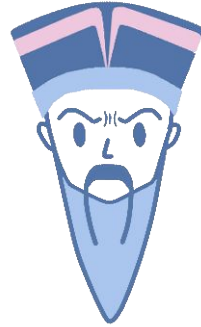
Week 9 Book of Lord Shang

GenEd1091: Classical Chinese Philosophy and Political Theory





Terminology



Lord Shang = Shang Yang = Kung-sun Yang = Wei Yang

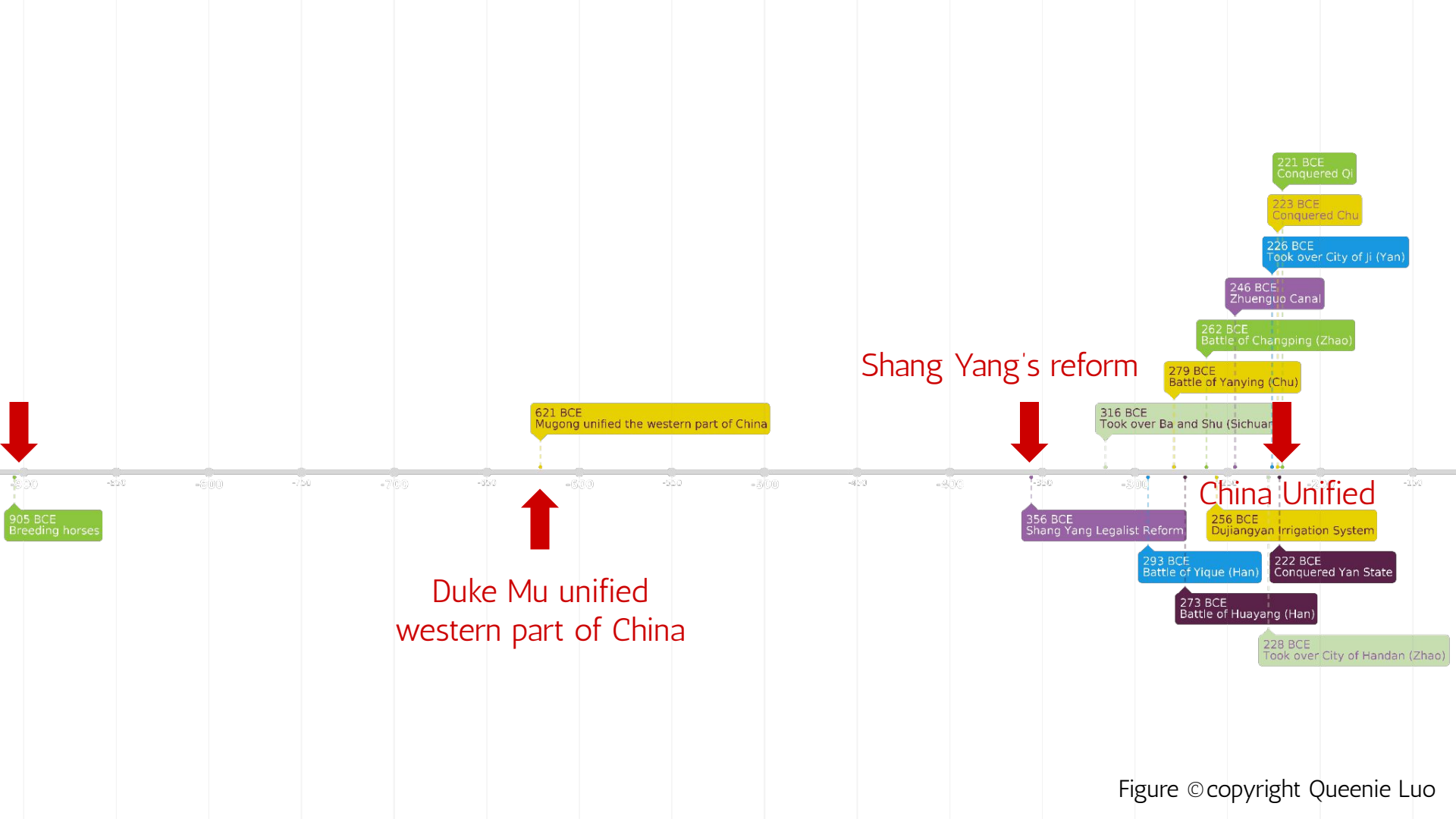
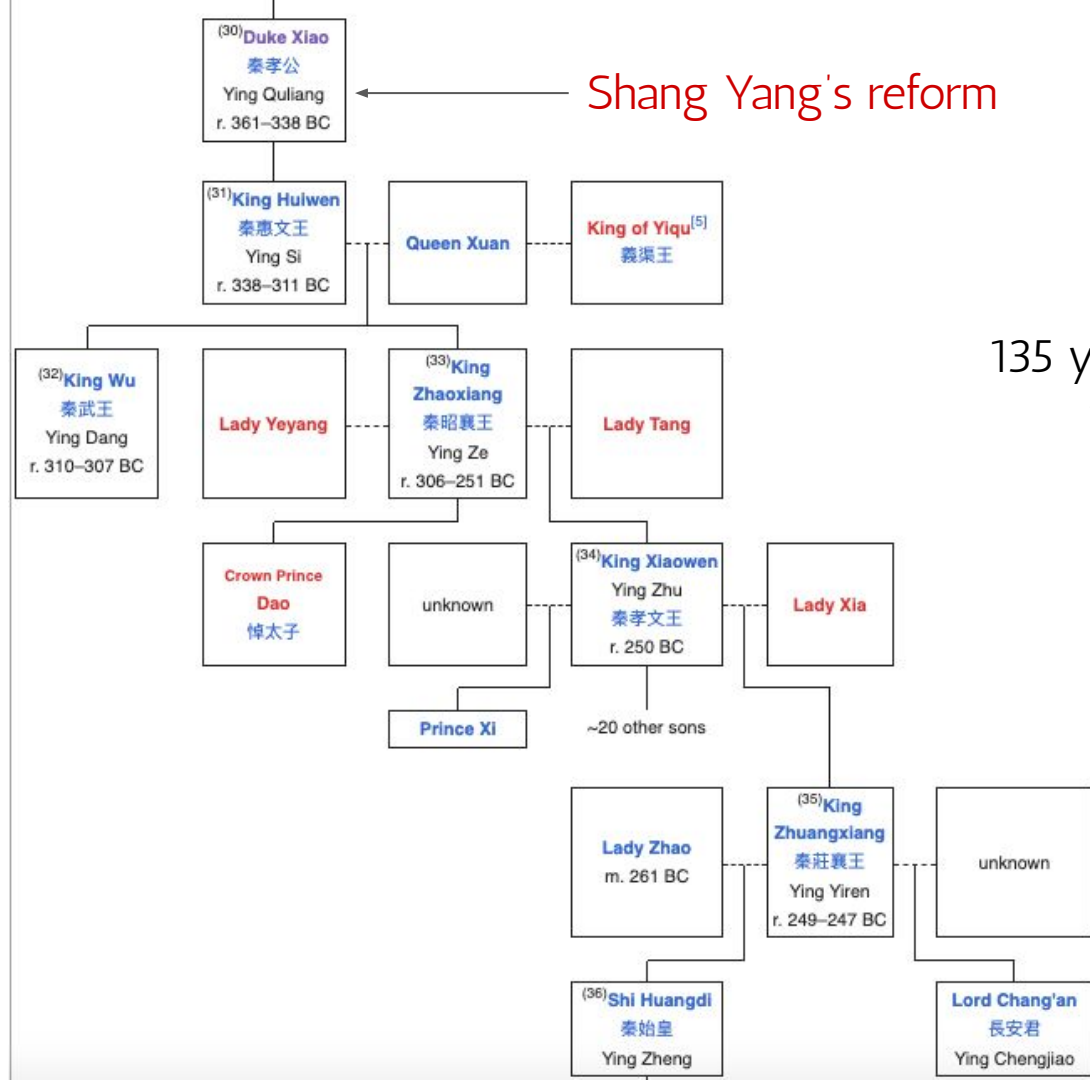


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135 years, 6 generations
to unify China

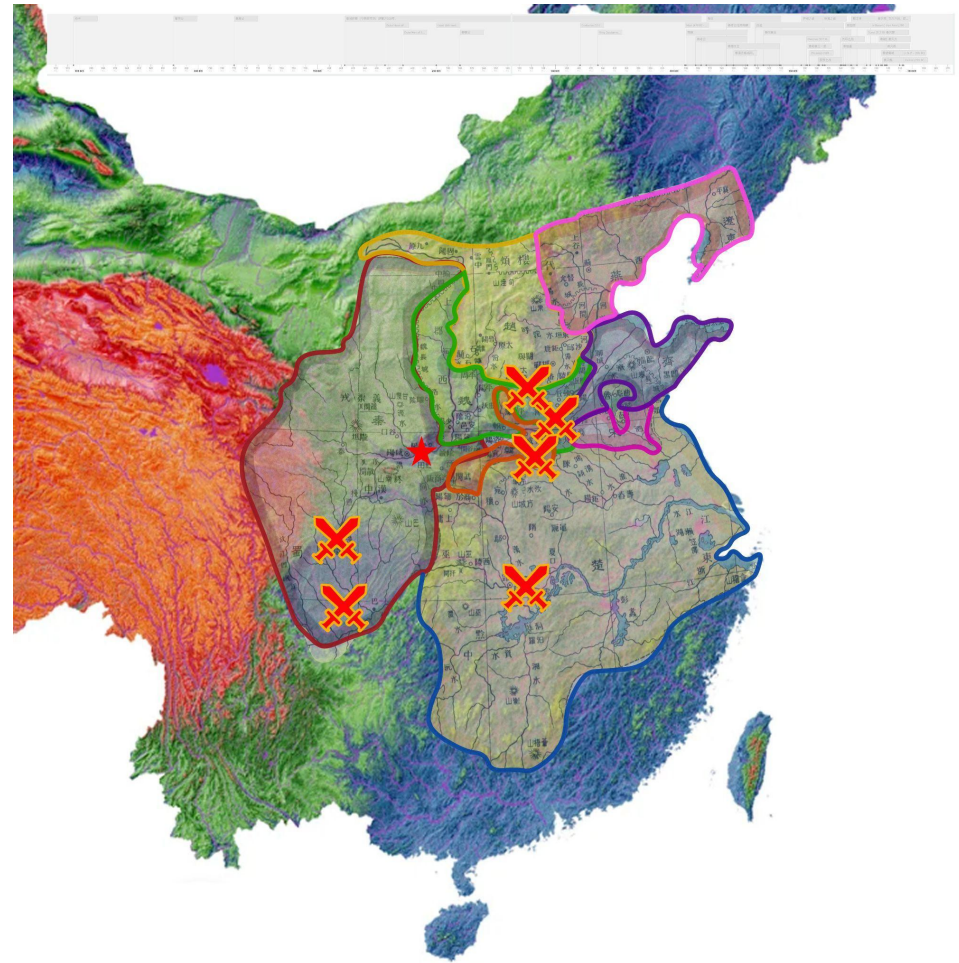
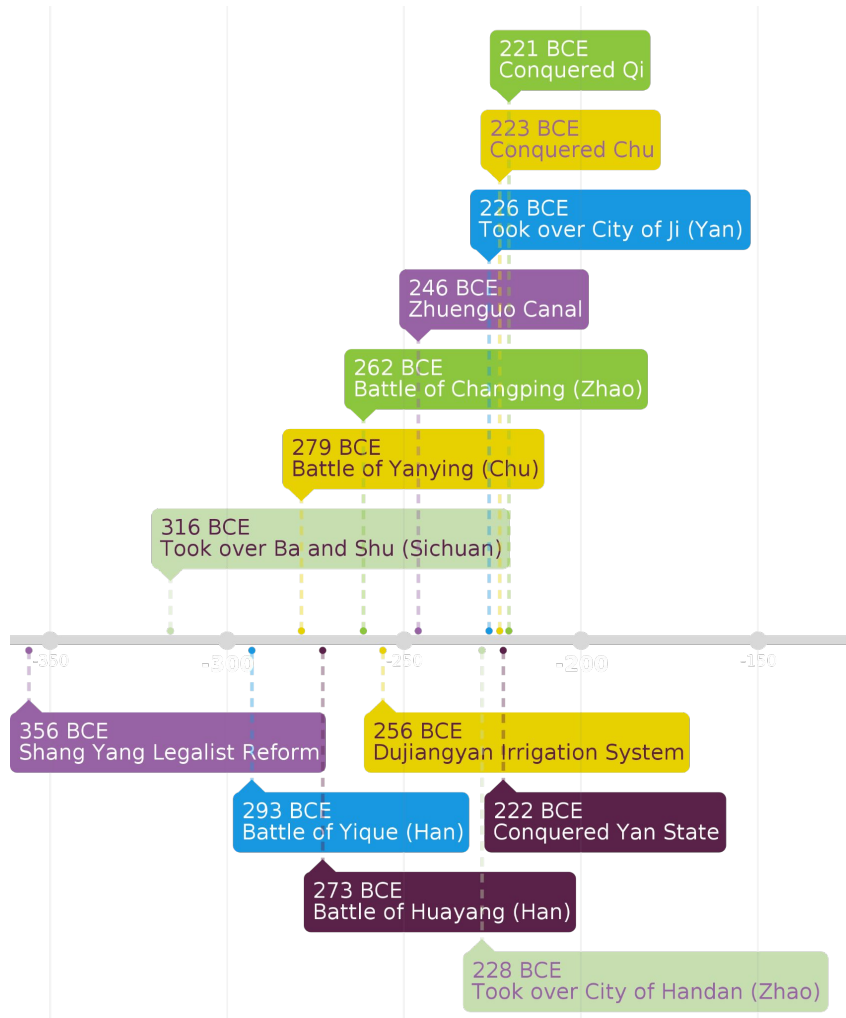


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Aspect	Shang Yang	Confucius	Mencius	Laozi	Zhuangzi	Xunzi
Core Focus	Legalism, state power, agriculture, and military	Moral education, virtue, and ethical governance	Benevolence, righteousness, and welfare of the people	Harmony with Dao, simplicity	Harmony with Dao, simplicity, skepticism of rigid systems	Education and ritual, strong governance
View on Governance	Strong laws and strict adherence for stability	Rule by moral example and virtuous leadership	Rule by enlightened and benevolent leaders	Non-interventionist, lead by example	Non-interventionist, skepticism towards authority	Strong laws and rituals to manage human nature
View on Education	Practical over cultural studies, focus on state needs	Emphasis on classics for moral development	Education for cultivating virtues	Intuitive knowledge over formal education	Skepticism towards structured education	Importance of education for overcoming inherent flaws
Social Structure	Hierarchical, roles defined by state contributions	Hierarchical but based on merit and virtue	Hierarchical, compassionate leadership	Non-hierarchical, flexible	Non-hierarchical, emphasis on individual freedom	Hierarchical, based on order maintained by rituals



Theme 1: The Reform of the Law

The prince (Duke Hsiao) said: I intend, now, to alter the laws, so as to obtain orderly government, and to reform the rites, so as to teach the people ; but I am afraid the empire will criticize me.

Kung-sun Yang said: ...He who is concerned about the highest virtue is not in harmony with popular ideas ; he who accomplishes a great work, does not take counsel with the multitude. The law is an expression of love for the people; rites are a means for making things run smoothly. Therefore a sage, if he is able to strengthen the state thereby, does not model himself on antiquity, and if he is able to benefit the people thereby, does not adhere to the established rites.

Kan Lung (does not agree with Kung-sun Yang) and said: if Your Highness alters the laws without adhering to the old customs of the Ch'in state, and reforms the rites in order to teach the people, I am afraid that the empire will criticize Your Highness, and I wish that You would reflect maturely.

Kung-sun Yang replied: ... a wise man creates laws, but a foolish man is controlled by them; a man of talent reforms rites, but a worthless man is enslaved by them. With a man who is enslaved by rites, it is not worth while to speak about matters ; with a man who is controlled by laws, it is not worth while to discuss reform. Let Your Highness not hesitate.

Duke Hsiao said : — Excellent! ... Thereupon, in consequence, he issued the order to bring waste lands under cultivation.



Theme 2: An Order to Cultivate Waste Lands

“If there is no procrastination in the creating of order, **depraved officials have no opportunity of gaining private profits at the expense of the people**, nor will the hundred officials be in a condition to temporise and to shift responsibilities on to one another. If the hundred officials are not in a condition to temporise and shift responsibilities on to one another, then **agriculture will know days of surplus**; and if the depraved officials have no opportunity of gaining private profits at the expense of the people, then agriculture will not be ruined. If agriculture is not ruined, but knows days of surplus, then it is certain **waste lands will be brought under cultivation.**”



Theme 2: An Order to Cultivate Waste Lands

“If **taxes are levied according to the measure of grain**, then the ruler will have system and consequently the people will have peace. If the ruler has system, he will be a man of his word, and being a man of his word, the officials will not dare to commit any depravity. **If the people have peace, they are circumspect, and being circumspect, they are difficult to move.** If the ruler is a man of his word and in consequence the officials dare not commit any depravity, and if the people are circumspect and consequently difficult to move, then there will be no criticism by inferiors of superiors, nor will the officials be regarded as obnoxious. If so, then the able-bodied will be strenuous in agriculture, without changing. If the able-bodied are so, then the youthful will learn it without resting, and when the youthful learn it without resting, it is certain **waste lands will be brought under cultivation.**”



Theme 2: An Order to Cultivate Waste Lands

“If dignities are not conferred nor office given according to deviating standards, then the people will not prize learning nor, besides, will they hold agriculture cheap. **If they do not prize learning, they will be stupid, and being stupid, they will have no interest in outside things ; when they have no interest in outside things, the country will exert itself in agriculture and not neglect it, and when the people do not hold agriculture cheap, the country will be peaceful and free from peril.** If the country is peaceful and free from peril, exerts itself in agriculture and does not neglect it, then it is certain waste lands will be brought under cultivation.”



Theme 2: An Order to Cultivate Waste Lands

“If salaries are liberal and consequently taxes numerous, then the large number of persons who live on others would mean ruin for agriculture ; but if they are assessed according to the calculated number of persons who live on others and are made to work hard, then the wicked and licentious, idle and lazy will have nothing on which to live, and **having nothing on which to live, they will take up agriculture; when they take up agriculture, then it is certain waste lands will be brought under cultivation.”**



Theme 2: An Order to Cultivate Waste Lands

“Do not allow merchants to buy grain nor farmers to sell grain. If farmers may not sell their grain, then the lazy and inactive ones will exert themselves and be energetic ; and, if merchants may not buy grain, then they have no particular joy over abundant years. Having no particular joy over abundant years, **they do not make copious profit in years of famine**, and making no copious profit, merchants are fearful, and being fearful, they desire to turn farmers. If lazy and inactive farmers exert themselves and become energetic, and **if merchants desire to turn farmers, then it is certain waste lands will be brought under cultivation.**”



Theme 3: Agriculture and War

"Where **a hundred men farm and one is idle, the state will attain supremacy** ; where ten men farm and one is idle, the state will be strong ; where half farms and half is idle, the state will be in peril." (p. 11)

"A sage knows what is essential in administering a country, and so he induces the people to devote their attention to agriculture. **If their attention is devoted to agriculture, then they will be simple, and being simple, they may be made correct.** Being perplexed, it will be easy to direct them; being trustworthy, they may be used for defence and warfare. Being single-minded, opportunities of deceit will be few, and they will attach importance to their homes. Being single-minded, their careers may be made dependent on rewards and penalties ; **being single-minded, they may be used abroad.**" (p.12)



Theme 3: Agriculture and War

"If, in a country, there are the following ten things : odes and history, rites and music, virtue and the cultivation thereof, benevolence and integrity, sophistry and intelligence, then the ruler has no one whom he can employ for defence and warfare. If a country is governed by means of these ten things, it will be dismembered as soon as an enemy approaches, and even if no enemy approaches, it will be poor. But if a country banishes these ten things, enemies will not dare to approach, and even if they should, they would be driven back. **When it mobilizes its army and attacks, it will gain victories ; when it holds the army in reserve and does not attack, it will be rich.** A country that loves strength makes assaults with what is difficult, and thus it will be successful. A country that loves sophistry makes assaults with what is easy, and thus it will be in danger." (p. 11)



Theme 4: Rewards and Punishments

"A country that has no strength and that practises knowledge and cleverness, will certainly perish; but a fearful people, stimulated by penalties, will become brave, and a brave people, encouraged by rewards, will fight to the death. If fearful people become brave and brave people fight to the death, (the country will have no match); having no match, it will be strong, and being strong it will attain supremacy.

If the poor are encouraged by rewards, they will become rich, and if penalties are applied to the rich, they will become poor. **When in administrating a country one succeeds in making the poor rich and the rich poor, then the country will have much strength, and this being the case, it will attain supremacy."** (p.14)



Theme 4: Rewards and Punishments

The way in which a sage administers a state is by **unifying rewards, unifying punishments, and unifying education**. The effect of unifying rewards is that the army will have no equal ; the effect of unifying punishments is that orders will be carried out ; the effect of unifying education is that inferiors will obey superiors...

What I mean by the **unifying of rewards is that profits and emoluments, office and rank, should be determined exclusively by military merit**, and that there should not be different reasons for distributing them. For thus the intelligent and the stupid, the noble and the humble, the brave and the timorous, the virtuous and the worthless, will all apply to the full whatever knowledge they may have in their breasts, exert to the uttermost whatever strength they may have in their limbs, and will be **at the service of their ruler even to death**; and the outstanding heroes, the virtuous and the good, of the whole empire will follow him, like flowing water, with the result that the army will have no equal, and commands will be carried out throughout the whole empire.



Post a reflection on Ed

- Prompt: Apply **one** concept from the *Book of Lord Shang* to a real-world scenario and share your thoughts. You may either agree or disagree with the text's ideas.
- Post it on Ed under “Sections” > “Week 9 Lord Shang”
- **Submit the link of your post to Canvas > Assignments**